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The PhD Rescue Checklist

12 Things Every Struggling PhD Student
Should Do Before Their Next Supervisor Meeting

12

action steps

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You Are Not Failing. You Are Under-Supported.

Every PhD student hits a wall. Sometimes it happens in Year 1 when the literature feels impossible to organise. Sometimes it happens in Year 3 when the methodology unravels before a critical deadline. Sometimes it's the night before a supervisor meeting, staring at a chapter that doesn't say what you mean it to say.

This checklist is not about making you feel better. It is about giving you 12 concrete actions you can take right now — before your next supervisor meeting — so that you walk in prepared, in control, and with a clear path forward.

Use the checkbox on each card. Work through them in order. By the time you reach item 12, you will have a different relationship with your PhD than you do right now.

Who this checklist is for

You if you have a supervisor meeting coming up and you don't feel ready. **You** if your thesis is stuck and you don't know where to start. **You** if you've been told a chapter needs to be rewritten and you don't know how. **You** if you're in Year 2, 3, or 4 and the finish line feels further away than it did when you started.

This checklist has helped 500+ PhD students in 42+ countries get unstuck.

■ Print or keep open

■ Check off each item

■ Do the ACTION step

■ Repeat before every meeting

SECTION A Preparation

Items 1–4: Get your head and your work ready

1

MINDSET

☐

Write down the 3 things your supervisor is most likely to ask you

The single biggest cause of bad supervisor meetings is being caught off guard. Your supervisor will almost certainly ask about progress, next steps, and problems. If you don't know your answers before you walk in, you will leave the meeting feeling like you failed — even if the session was fine. Anticipating the questions is half the preparation.

ACTION:

Write 3 likely questions + your 1-sentence answer to each. Do this tonight.

2

WRITING

☐

Read your last submitted chapter or section aloud

Reading your own writing aloud forces you to hear what you actually wrote, not what you meant to write. You will catch sentences that are too long, arguments that don't connect, and conclusions that don't follow from the evidence. Do this for the section your supervisor most recently reviewed — this is what they are reacting to.

ACTION:

Set a timer for 20 minutes. Read aloud. Mark every sentence where you stumble.

3

PLANNING

☐

Create a one-page 'thesis map' showing where you are right now

Your supervisor needs to see that you understand your own project structure. A one-page thesis map lists all chapters with their status (done / in progress / not started), the key argument of each chapter, and how they connect. It takes 30 minutes to make and completely changes the quality of your supervisor conversation.

ACTION:

Draw your thesis map on paper first. Then type it up. Bring a printed copy.

4

DATA



Identify the one result you don't fully understand yet

In almost every PhD, there is a result, finding, or data point that the student hasn't fully explained — even to themselves. If your supervisor asks about it, you will be caught unprepared. Before your meeting, identify it, write down what it shows, what you think it means, and what the alternative interpretations are. Own it before they ask.

ACTION:

Write a 3-sentence explanation of your most uncertain result. Practise saying it.

SECTION B

Knowledge & Writing

Items 5–8: Show evidence of academic rigour

5

LITERATURE



Find 3 papers published in the last 6 months relevant to your topic

One of the most common supervisor complaints is that students aren't staying current with the literature. Before your meeting, run a quick search — Google Scholar, PubMed, or Semantic Scholar — and find 3 recent papers. Read the abstract and conclusions. You don't need to have read the full paper. You need to demonstrate that you are tracking your field.

ACTION:

Search '[your topic] 2024 OR 2025' on Google Scholar. Save 3 papers. Note 1 sentence per paper.

6

WRITING



Write a 100-word summary of your entire thesis as if explaining to a friend

If you cannot explain your thesis in plain language, you don't yet understand it well enough to write it. This is not a criticism — it is a diagnostic. Write a 100-word plain-English summary of what you're doing, why it matters, and what you expect to find. This exercise will reveal gaps in your own thinking before your supervisor does.

ACTION:

Write the 100 words right now. No jargon. Set a 10-minute timer.

7

METHODOLOGY

**Prepare a one-sentence justification for every key methodological choice**

Your supervisor — and your examiners — will question your methodology. Why this sample size? Why this analysis? Why this model? If you don't have a clear, confident one-sentence answer for each decision, prepare them now. You don't need a 3-page justification. You need a clear, evidence-based sentence you can say confidently without hesitation.

ACTION:

List every major methodological choice. Write 1 sentence of justification for each.

8

PROGRESS

**Be honest with yourself: what have you actually completed since your last meeting?**

Write down exactly what you have done since your last supervisor meeting — not what you planned to do, what you actually did. This is not about judging yourself. It is about being honest with your supervisor and with yourself. Most supervisors respond far better to honest progress reports than to vague optimism. Honesty rebuilds trust. Vagueness destroys it.

ACTION:

Make a factual list: what was done, what wasn't, and one clear reason for each gap.

ACTION C

Action & Confidence

Items 9–12: Own your progress and your next steps

9

NEXT STEPS

**Prepare a specific 2-week action plan with dates to share with your supervisor**

The best thing you can do at the end of any supervisor meeting is hand over a specific 2-week plan — not goals, but actions, with dates. 'I will complete the results section for Chapter 3 by [date]' is a plan. 'I will try to write more' is not. This transforms your supervisor from a judge into an accountability partner.

ACTION:

Write your 2-week plan with specific tasks and specific dates before the meeting.

10

WELLBEING

**Identify one specific thing that is blocking your progress — and say it out loud**

Most PhD students do not tell their supervisors what is really holding them back — data access, a confusing feedback, a personal situation, or simply not understanding a concept. Supervisors cannot help with problems they don't know about. Before your meeting, name the one real blocker. Write it down. Then decide if you are going to raise it.

ACTION:

Write: 'The one thing blocking me most right now is ____.' Decide if you will share it.

11

COMMUNICATION

**Prepare one specific question you need your supervisor to answer**

Supervisor meetings should not be one-directional. Come in with a specific question you need answered — not 'do you think my thesis is going well?' but 'I'm unsure whether to include X in Chapter 2 because of Y — what would you recommend?' Specific questions get specific answers. Vague check-ins get vague feedback.

ACTION:

Write your one specific question. Make sure it can't be answered with 'yes' or 'no'.

12

CONFIDENCE

**Read your original research question and remember why you started this PhD**

By the time you reach this point in the checklist, you have done significant work. The last item is the most important: go back to the beginning. Read your original research question or proposal. Read why you wanted to do this research. Your supervisor meeting is about a PhD that you chose, that you are capable of completing, and that matters. Walk in remembering that.

ACTION:

Read your original research proposal or statement of purpose. Bring one sentence from it to the meeting.

What Happens If the Checklist Isn't Enough?

For many PhD students, working through these 12 items will be enough to walk into your supervisor meeting with clarity and confidence. But for some — particularly those dealing with a rewrite, a serious methodology challenge, a publication pressure, or a tight submission deadline — a checklist is the beginning, not the end.

That is what BioAI Lab exists for. We are a PhD-level expert support platform — every specialist we work with holds a doctorate in their specific domain. We don't offer generic academic help. We offer domain-matched expert partnership.

◆ Dissertation & thesis writing	Chapter writing, methodology, lit review, committee-ready
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◆ Grant proposal writing	NIH R01/R21, NSF, DBT, ICMR, Wellcome Trust, H2020
◆ Policy documents	White papers, biosafety policy, regulatory submissions

500+	\$18M+	350+	87%
Researchers Supported	Grants Secured	Papers in Q1/Q2 Journals	Grant Success Rate

Ready to Turn This Checklist Into Action?

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